

## **After the Story: No Fourth Cut**

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A companion study to *The Nail Box*

### **Back to Lock 44**

Pull your chair closer. We're going back down to the Freemansburg flats, between Main Street and Lock 44, where the towpath still holds the shape of mule work and the locktender's stone house keeps its aluminum roof the color of old tin. The wind off the Lehigh comes up the bank once the sun drops behind the South Mountain ridge. You can smell river water and wet leaves and somebody's leaf pile burning two blocks over.

Cole Bachman is thirty-two. Three weeks after they buried his father, Frank, he cleared the garage of a brick half-double with the canal behind the back fence. Behind leftover trim on a high shelf he found a maple nail box, oil-darkened, six compartments, hinged lid. On the lid, in Frank's block print: CUT LIST INSIDE. KEEP SQUARE. Under the nails sat a pocket Gospel of John with carpenter margins. Beside John 5: MY FATHER / NOT OUR / EQUAL CLAIM / CHECK JOINT. Beside John 8:58: I AM / BEFORE THE BOARD WAS LAID. At John 10:30: SAME STOCK / SQUARE TRUE OR THROW THE STICK. At John 14:6: NO BYPASS / ONLY RUN. Beside Thomas in John 20: ACCEPT OR REJECT / NO MIDDLE KERF. On the blank inside back cover Frank had drawn a cut list the way he'd draw one for cabinet sides:

CLAIM: GOD

IF LIE: LIAR

IF MAD: LUNATIC

IF TRUE: LORD

GOOD TEACHER = BAD JOINT

NO 4TH CUT

That Saturday Derek and Manny helped haul the heavy stuff. Derek is a good man with a framing nailer and a kid in Tee Ball. He likes Jesus the way a lot of men like Jesus: the parts

about being kind, and he skips the parts where Jesus talks like God. Down by the canal bank they built a fire with scrap pine from Frank's pile. Derek read the back cover out loud and said he didn't buy it. Jesus was a good teacher. Best one. Doesn't mean He was God.

Cole did not preach. He took Frank's Starrett combination square and a scrap of clear pine. On three faces he printed LIAR, LUNATIC, LORD. On the fourth face, the soft edge Derek wanted, he printed TEACHER. The square sat quiet on LIAR and LUNATIC. On TEACHER the blade rocked and the vial refused to settle. On LORD the blade went flush. Cole drove a sixteen-penny nail through LORD, snapped Frank's chalk line true across the top, put the Gospel and the square and the chalk line back in the maple, and latched the hook until it clicked. Derek still said he thought Jesus was a teacher. Cole said he was not Derek's Holy Spirit. The scrap with the nail through LORD stayed in the dirt by the ring. The lock-gate sound Cole heard later that night stayed unanswered.

Tonight we're going to sit with that fire and ask what Frank's cut list already knew, and what Josh and Sean McDowell confirm with ordinary words in *More Than a Carpenter*.

### **Questions to Sit With**

1. Read John 5:16-18, John 8:58, and John 10:30. Jesus called God His own Father, claimed the forever Name before Abraham, and said He and the Father are one. Frank wrote SAME STOCK on that claim. What cut does the soft edge of "good teacher only" leave open in that joint?
2. Read John 20:24-29, where Thomas meets the risen Christ and names Him Lord and God, and Mark 2:1-12, where Jesus forgives sins and the room knows only God can do that. Derek wants teacher without Maker. What does accepting worship and forgiving sin do to that fourth cut?
3. Read Matthew 16:15, where Jesus asks His own men who they say He is. McDowell says you must make a choice. Cole's hands finished the choice with a square and a nail while Derek walked away unconverted. What does your own hand do with the scrap when the soft edge won't hold?

## The Teaching: No Fourth Cut

Start where Cole started. Not with a campus lecture. With a maple box and a cut list.

Frank Bachman did not write sermons in the margins of John. He wrote measurements. Josh and Sean McDowell open the same claim from another workbench. They write that the people who knew Jesus soon saw "those claims were identifying him as more than just a prophet or teacher" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 2). "He was obviously making claims to deity" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 2). That is Frank's MY FATHER / NOT OUR beside John 5. That is I AM / BEFORE THE BOARD WAS LAID beside John 8:58. That is SAME STOCK / SQUARE TRUE OR THROW THE STICK at John 10:30. The Gospel does not leave Jesus as a wise voice you can hang on a shop wall next to other wise voices. He talks like the Owner of the stock.

Hold that against Derek's soft edge. Derek is not a villain. He hangs doors. He loves his kid. He will say Jesus is the best teacher in the room and mean it. Frank's back cover already named that move: GOOD TEACHER = BAD JOINT. McDowell names it the same way without a classroom chalkboard. "One who claimed what Jesus claimed about himself couldn't be a good moral man or a prophet. That option isn't open to us, and Jesus never intended it to be" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3). Cole did not argue that sentence at Derek. He set a Starrett on a TEACHER face that rocked. The tool told the truth the cut list already held. The soft edge won't hold.

Walk the three cuts the way the scrap walked them.

First face: LIAR. If Jesus knew He was not God and said He was, the joint is fraud. McDowell puts it plain: "If, when Jesus made his claims, he knew that he was not God, then he was lying and deliberately deceiving his followers" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3). Then the rest of the face comes into the light. A liar who taught honesty at any cost is a hypocrite. A liar who told people to trust him with forever is worse than a bad salesman. McDowell presses the point carpenters already know about a bad claim: "How could he be a great moral teacher and knowingly mislead people at the most important point of his teaching-his own identity?" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3). You do not keep a man on the "good teacher" shelf after you admit he lied about being God. Frank wrote IF LIE: LIAR. Cole's square sat quiet on that face. The claim is hard. It is also square with the words.

Second face: LUNATIC. Maybe He meant it and was wrong. Sincere and cracked. McDowell will not let that stay small. He writes that for a man "to mistakenly think himself God, especially in the context of a fiercely monotheistic culture, and then to tell others that their eternal destiny depended on believing in him, is no small flight of fancy but the delusions and ravings of an outright lunatic" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3). Frank wrote IF MAD: LUNATIC. Cole checked that face. The vial settled. If the claim is false and He believed it, you are not left with a gentle rabbi. You are left with a man whose forever-talk belongs in a locked ward, not on a youth-group bracelet.

Third face: LORD. If the claim is true, the cut is Lord. McDowell says what Cole's hands finally marked: "I cannot personally conclude that Jesus was a liar or a lunatic. The only other alternative is that he was-and is-the Christ, the Son of God, as he claimed" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3). Frank wrote IF TRUE: LORD. Cole turned the scrap. Flush. Sixteen-penny nail through the word. Chalk line true across the top. Hands latched the box. Tools finished the decision. No syllogism on a whiteboard. A carpenter's son doing what his father's cut list told him the wall required.

Now the fourth face again, because that is where most of us live until somebody hands us a square. Derek wanted TEACHER as a safe leftover cut. McDowell closes the leftover: "You cannot put him on the shelf merely as a great moral teacher or a prophet. That is not a valid option. He is either a liar, a lunatic, or Lord and God. You must make a choice" (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3). Frank wrote NO 4TH CUT. Cole left the rocking TEACHER face where Derek could see it and did not chase him up the bank with a tract. Derek crushed his can. Derek talked Tee Ball. Derek stayed on the soft edge. The lesson does not force a conversion ending. The fire still burns. The scrap still stands in the dirt. The choice still sits in your hands.

Scripture keeps the same pressure without a translation quote in our mouths. Jesus asks His men who they say He is (Matthew 16:15). Thomas puts his fingers to the wounds and names Him Lord and God, and Jesus does not correct the worship (John 20). Jesus forgives sins in a crowded house, and the room knows what that claim costs (Mark 2). Frank heard those passages the way a framer hears a wall: accept or reject, no middle kerf. McDowell, writing years later for readers who still want a bypass, keeps pointing at the same exclusive run Jesus named for Himself. There is no fourth cut that keeps the joint closed.

The veil got thin that night for Cole when he thought he heard Lock 44's gates move, and the chamber was empty when he looked. We do not settle that sound for him. We settle the cut list. CLAIM: GOD. Then the only faces that keep a wall standing. LIAR. LUNATIC. LORD. The soft edge rocks. Latch the box when your hands are done.

### **Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home**

Talk about the Derek in your crew, or the Derek in your own chest. The man who will praise Jesus as teacher and stop short of Lord. Say out loud which face you have been living on. Frank and McDowell are on the same side of that question. Softening the claim into "good teacher only" will not make the joint hold when the seasons turn.

Talk about Cole's tools. He did not win Derek with a speech. He put a Starrett on scrap and let a rocking blade do the talking. Where do you still try to argue a man into square when his hands have not held the claim yet? Where do you need to quit being somebody else's Holy Spirit and leave the nailed scrap by the ring?

Talk about the unanswered lock-gate and the unconverted friend. It is all right that Derek walked away still saying teacher. Scripture did not appoint Cole to close Derek's file that night. What Scripture did give us is a claim, three honest cuts, and a question from Jesus that still lands in the mouth: who do you say I am? That is enough wood for one fire.

Try this, this week. Read John 5, John 8:58, John 10:30, and John 20 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand the way Frank used a pencil. Write your own block-print margin on one page. Keep it short. Keep it a cut list, not a sermon. Then take a scrap of wood, or a note card if wood is not in reach, and write LIAR, LUNATIC, TEACHER, LORD on four edges. Ask which face your life has been building on. If the soft edge is where you have been resting, set a square on it in prayer and tell the truth about the rock. Learn Matthew 16:15 by heart as a paraphrase you can say by a canal: who do you say I am? Put another piece of cedar on. Keep the fire high enough to show you the towpath and the faces both. And when a friend stays on the soft edge, leave the nail through LORD where the fire can see it, latch your own box, and refuse the fourth cut.

## **Works Cited**

McDowell, Josh, and Sean McDowell. *More Than a Carpenter*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale House, 2009.